

damaging to both finances and wellbeing over time. If you've had problem debt in the past, as I have, I've found that learning to use credit well can really help to heal some of that guilt and shame that might follow you even once the debt is paid off. The confidence that I feel in being able to use a credit card wisely and appropriately, pay off the balance each month and spread the cost of larger items cheaply, is a feeling that I coveted for such a long time when I was plagued by beliefs that I was 'bad with money'. One of the repeating themes in this book is the importance of learning to trust yourself to make the right decisions with money, and using credit can be a huge test of that – it's completely understandable if you'd rather avoid it altogether, but try not to be afraid of it.

So, how do we decide when credit could be a good option? Here are a few things to make sure you have in place before you borrow:

- You understand the terms of your agreement to borrow money, and any penalties or consequences if you can't pay.
- You've taken enough time to consider whether it's worth taking on this financial commitment.
- You can afford the repayments and have added them to your budget.
- You aren't just spreading or delaying the cost for the sake of it.
- There's a benefit to getting the product or service now, rather than waiting until you've saved up for it.